Democrats win Congress

Democrats won both parts of Congress. The president was not on the ballot, but many people see the result as a message to him and his party.

Level 2 · B1 · 206 words · 12.1 words per sentence · 7 glossed

On Tuesday, November 3, Americans voted in the midterms, the elections that take place halfway through a president's term. Donald Trump was not on the ballot, but his Republican Party was.

The Democrats won control of the House of Representatives and of the Senate. Before the vote, the Republicans had a majority in both. In the Senate, they had 53 seats against 47. Now the Democrats have 54, and a few races are still too close to call.

The Democrats also won in some very conservative states. The AP names Iowa, Texas and Kansas, and says they won in places that Trump won by double digits two years ago.

Why? The AP says voters were unhappy about high prices, the war in Iran and corruption in the government.

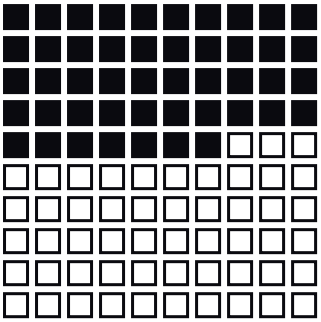
Trump said he would accept the results. He did not call the vote a personal defeat. He blamed some Republican candidates instead, and he said he will veto laws from the Democrats. Republican leader John Thune said his party will work with Trump to stop what he called the extreme ideas of the Democrats.

The new Congress starts on January 3. Until then, nothing changes in the Senate. After that date, the Democrats will lead the committees and can investigate the administration.

GLOSSARY

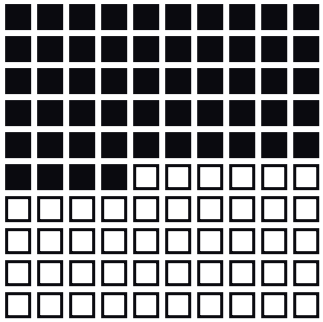
midterms	eleições de meio de mandato
on the ballot	na cédula
seats	cadeiras
too close to call	apertadas demais para dar o resultado
by double digits	por mais de dez pontos
blamed	culpou
committees	comissões

THE SENATE, 100 SEATS



47

Before the vote



54

Nov 4, 2026

■ Democrats (and 2 independents)

□ Republicans

In 2026, the empty squares are Republican seats or seats not yet called.

Source: AP and news reports, Nov 4, 2026. Some races were still being counted.

Two systems, side by side

In the text: the House = *a Câmara dos Deputados*, the Senate = o *Senado Federal*. Both countries have two chambers, but they work in different ways.

	UNITED STATES	BRASIL
TWO CHAMBERS	House of Representatives and Senate	*Câmara dos Deputados* and *Senado Federal*
SEATS	435 in the House, 100 in the Senate	513 *deputados*, 81 *senadores*
SENATORS	2 for each state	3 for each state and for the Federal District (*Distrito Federal*)
TERMS	House: 2 years. Senate: 6 years.	*Câmara*: 4 years. *Senado*: 8 years.
ELECTIONS	Every 2 years: the whole House and one third of the Senate. The president is chosen in a different year, so these elections fall in the middle of the president's term. That is why they are called midterms.	Every 4 years, all together: president, governors, *Câmara* and part of the Senate (one third, then two thirds). There is no midterm for Congress. The elections 2 years later are for mayors (*prefeitos*).
WHO GETS A SEAT	House: each district elects one member. The candidate with the most votes wins.	*Câmara*: parties win seats in proportion to their votes. Each state has from 8 to 70 deputies, depending on its population.
VETO	To override a veto, two thirds of each chamber must vote against it.	To override a veto (*derrubar o veto*), an absolute majority of each chamber is enough: 257 deputies and 41 senators, in a joint session.
THE PRESIDENT'S PICKS	The Senate approves cabinet members, judges and ambassadors.	The *Senado* approves ambassadors and Supreme Court (STF) judges. Ministers do not need approval.
IMPEACHMENT	The House accuses, by a simple majority. The Senate judges: two thirds must vote to remove.	The *Câmara* must authorize it: 342 of 513 votes. The *Senado* judges: 54 of 81 votes remove the president.

Sources: Senado Federal, Câmara dos Deputados, Constituição Federal (arts. 45, 46, 52, 66), U.S. Constitution.

AFTER READING

1. Who was on the ballot on November 3, and who was not?
2. According to the AP, what did voters care about?
3. Do you think the results of midterm elections change how much power a president has? Why?

SOURCES

PBS NewsHour (AP), Democrats win control of U.S. House, in major rebuke to Trump

Al Jazeera, Democrats win Congress: How they did it, and what it means

Time, Democrats Win Control of Both House and Senate in Huge Blow to Trump

CBS News, 2026 midterm election updates as fallout begins over sweeping Democratic victories

CNBC, Midterm Election Day recap: Democrats flip Senate and House

Senado Federal, Perguntas frequentes

Câmara dos Deputados, The Federal Senate

U.S. News, 2026 Midterm Election Results: Maps Show How Democrats Took Congress